



ZIMBABWE

Capital city: Harare**Area:** 150,803 sq miles
(390,580 sq km)**Population:** 12,900,000**Official language:**
English**Major religions:** Syncretic
(part Christian, part
traditional beliefs) 50%,
Christian 25%, traditional
beliefs 24%, other 1%**Government:** Multiparty
democracy**Currency:** Zimbabwe
dollar**Adult literacy rate:** 90%**Life expectancy:** 39 years**People per doctor:** 10,000**Televisions:** 30 per 1,000
people

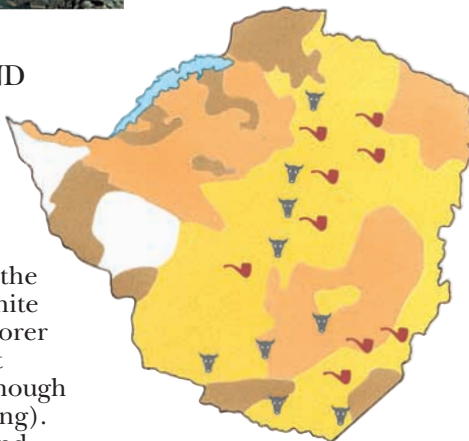
VICTORIA FALLS

As the Zambezi River flows eastward along the border between Zambia and Zimbabwe, it drops 420 ft (128 m) down into a narrow chasm. The thick mist and loud noise produced by the waterfall can be seen and heard up to 25 miles (40 km) away. Local people call the falls *Mosi-oa-tunya* ("the smoke that thunders"), but internationally they are known as the Victoria Falls.



FARMING THE LAND

The center of Zimbabwe is rich in fertile farmland, producing tobacco and other crops for selling (commercial farming). Until recently the best land was owned by white landowners, leaving the poorer areas to be farmed by about 5 million blacks, who grow enough to live on (subsistence farming). Mugabe's policy of seizing land from the whites has meant that many thousands of black farmworkers have lost their jobs, while Mugabe supporters have been given the best land.

Tobacco
plant

How the land is farmed

Commercial farming
Subsistence farming

Land unsuitable for farming
Tobacco
Cattle

ZIMBABWE

ZIMBABWE WAS ONCE PART OF a great trading empire. Many centuries ago, central African merchants exported gold and copper to India and China. The center of this empire was Great Zimbabwe ("house of the chief"), a huge palace, from which Zimbabwe took its name when it became independent in 1980. Today the country's economic potential has been ruined by the corrupt rule of the president, Robert Mugabe. He has oppressed opposition parties and his policy of encouraging illegal occupation of white-owned farmland by black settlers has caused food shortages and economic chaos.

ECONOMIC CRISIS

A few years ago Zimbabwe had one of the most successful economies in Africa. During the Ethiopian drought in the 1980s it was the only country in the region to export food there. However, political uncertainty has had a destabilizing effect on the economy and jobs have been lost in all sectors. The country no longer has regular supplies of oil, as it does not have the foreign currency required to pay for them, and this has led to gas shortages.



FIGHTING OPPRESSION

Robert Mugabe's Zanu-PF party has been in power since the country's independence in 1980. The harsh rule imposed by him, and widespread corruption of his party, led to the formation of the Movement for Democratic Change (MDC) in September 1999. This party campaigns for an end to political oppression, but supporters risk violent attacks by Mugabe supporters.



THE SHONA PEOPLES

The majority of Zimbabweans are Shona (or Mashona) peoples, who live in the center and east of the country. Many make a living from farming or, increasingly, work in industry. Many Shona people are Christians, but they also believe in animism, that is that natural objects such as lakes and trees have spirits. The Shona are known for their pottery and sculpture.

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